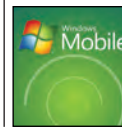


Did you know?

The Windows Mobile operating system is believed to be based on Windows CE, which was designed for simple computers and embedded systems

**6.5.1**

According to downloadsquad.com, Microsoft is already working on a update for Windows Mobile 6.5 with a rewritten, finger-friendly contact application

Win...Mo?

Sumeet Gugnani, Director, Communications Business, Microsoft on Windows Mobile 6.5

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Tell us a little bit about Windows Mobile 6.5 and what separates it from the rest?

Windows Mobile 6.5 is an inflection point for Microsoft for very fundamental reasons. For long, this industry has been dominated by hardware. People used to buy phones for their specs, the megapixel count of the camera, etc. Over the last few years, it moved up to the next level, which is hardware plus software. The software experience started becoming more important. That's when we came into the picture, because Microsoft is of course fundamentally a software player. Therefore, all our versions - Windows Mobile 3, 5, 6, and 6.1, have been talking about software as the key differentiator.

What Windows Mobile 6.5 brings to the table is our claim to the services side. At this point we're announcing two new services after a fair share of consumer insight. The first service is the MyPhone service that will be available with 6.0 and above, but is being launched right now. The insight that helped develop MyPhone, was the fact that a lot of people literally trust their phone to do everything for them. Their whole digital life is contained in this phone. People don't even carry multiple devices these days. Therefore in a situation where this phone gets lost, stolen, damaged, or misplaced, you just don't lose a device or machine worth 10,000 rupees, you lose your whole set of memories. Photographs - pictures of birthdays, family, friends, contacts, music - all gone in a stroke. What MyPhone does, is give you 200 MB of free storage on the cloud so everything that you have on your phone gets synchronised. All you need is a Windows Live ID and it syncs everything and anything you choose right from messages to music, videos, contacts, calendars, docs, etc. The stuff is all compressed when stored online but you can view it via a browser. So if you lose your phone apart from the expense of buying a new one, you can come back to the MyPhone web site and you have everything right back in to your phone. The transmission takes place via GPRS, and syncs can be scheduled and chosen as per convenience.

What are the other services on the new version?

The second service is Marketplace. This is interesting because it is new and old at the same time. It is new in the sense that with 6.5, this is the first time we're offering an application store on the mobile. But it is kind of old to the extent that applications is what we do for a living. We've got more than 20,000 applications already there through our developer ecosystem. So there's really a whole universe of applications available. But our challenge was not to get an x number of application up there. Earlier, we used to make it available through third-party web sites. Our challenge was how to certify and make sure what we give is the best. So we set up filter criteria on applications. For example, the application cannot be more than 10 MB in size. Eventually, consumer experience is important. Especially, what they download over the air - if it is more, then the experience is not that great and you end up consuming more bandwidth. Secondly, it cannot have any objectionable content. What is good for the developers is that there is no new learning curve. The SDK is the same, the .NET framework is the same, Visual Studio is the same. All the developers have to do, is use those, submit the application and we



take over. The R&D team will go through the application and certify it. Only after certification will it get placed on Marketplace. Once it does go there, it's placed in a fairly user friendly manner. You have the 'most popular' and category wise kind of organisation and a user rating system.

So can you still get third-party applications?

Yes you can as before, from third-party web sites. A very small subset of that will be certified. The third vector of differentiation has more to do with the UI. We're talking about the ability to personalise the screen to whatever you want. You can do cool stuff like have widgets from Windows 7 installed on winmo 6.5. Alternately you can go to a skin generator site to make a theme.

Tell us about your plans for India?

We always go through our partner ecosystems. So we have 6 or 7 leading names of the phone industry associated with us. We have more than 25 models. Each of those models, gives you a different user experience. You have form factor variations like touchscreen with a qwerty, a touchscreen with a slider, a non touch with a qwerty, and so on. In this way we have best of the evolution of hardware to service. We're actually very delighted with the progress we've made in India over the last three years. Back then we used to sell about 25,000 phones a year. Today we're selling about 3,00,000 phones a year. We're the fastest growing platform here. We outsell every other major smart phone player, with the exception of Nokia which is more a universal end-to-end kind of player. So the consumer acceptance of the Windows brand is very high.

Market share trends abroad are completely the opposite for Windows Mobile.

We don't see this as a market share game at all. For a very simple reason - a smartphone is hardly four percent of the phone universe. So this is really about market expansion. Who grows faster in that market, are dynamics that can change. Someone comes up with a great new something so sales spike. Apple came up with a great UI back then and they did well. But the point is this is a long term race and there are a few players in for the long haul. We're in it for the long haul. We were the first to innovate in this platform. With version 3 we gave people the option of pull mail, with 5 we shared push mail, 6 we said take HTML email, with 6.1 threaded SMS, with this one we have services. So we're here, we're gonna keep investing in R&D and over the years the choice is going to be made by the consumers. 